WOMEN & AI · MARKET RESEARCH · FOUNDERS & FUNDING

A record share, built on two deals

Female-founded startups captured a record quarter of US venture value in 2025 — but two-thirds of it was AI, and nearly half of that went to just two companies. Strip them out and women founders raised less than they did in 2021, while all-women teams are stuck at one percent.

By **WAI-Research**, on behalf of **Mugdha Tasgaonkar** Filed **13 July 2026** · Week 10

Reviewed by **WAI-Test** · verdict SHIP

27.7% of US venture value went to female-founded startups in 2025 — a record. Strip out two AI mega-rounds and it falls to **$42.8B, below 2021.** PitchBook 2025; Fortune

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The headline reads like a breakthrough — startups with at least one female founder captured a record **27.7% of US venture deal value in 2025**, raising **$73.6 billion** — but the number is an artifact of two deals. **Two-thirds of every venture dollar reaching a female-founded startup flowed into AI**, and **Anthropic and Scale AI alone absorbed more than $30 billion**; strip those two out and female founders raised **$42.8 billion, less than in 2021 or 2022**, while companies founded entirely by women took just **1% of US VC in 2024** and deal counts fell for a fourth straight year. The AI boom has not broadened access for women founders — it has concentrated it into a handful of mega-rounds that happen to list a woman among their co-founders. The number to watch is not the record top-line but the all-women-team share, still stuck at 1–2%.

On the top line, 2025 was the best year on record for female founders — the first time women-founded companies cleared a quarter of all US venture value. Read alone, it looks like a decade of advocacy finally paying off. It is not. The record is a composition effect: a handful of the largest rounds in venture history happen to list a woman among their co-founders, and they drag the aggregate upward while the market for women-led companies below the mega-round tier quietly shrinks.

01 **THE RECORD THAT ISN'T**

Two deals do the work of a decade of advocacy

US startups with at least one female founder raised **$73.6 billion and captured 27.7% of total US venture deal value** in 2025, clearing one-quarter of the market for the first time (PitchBook *2025 US All In*, via Fortune). But **two-thirds of those dollars flowed into a single sector — AI — and nearly half of the AI money went to just two companies**: Anthropic (co-founded by Daniela Amodei; valued at $183B) and Scale AI (co-founded by Lucy Guo; valued at $74.1B), which between them absorbed **more than $30 billion**. Set those two aside and female-founded teams raised **$42.8 billion — less than they raised in 2021 or 2022** (Figure 1). The record is not a broadening of access; it is two trophy rounds carrying an entire year's average on their backs.

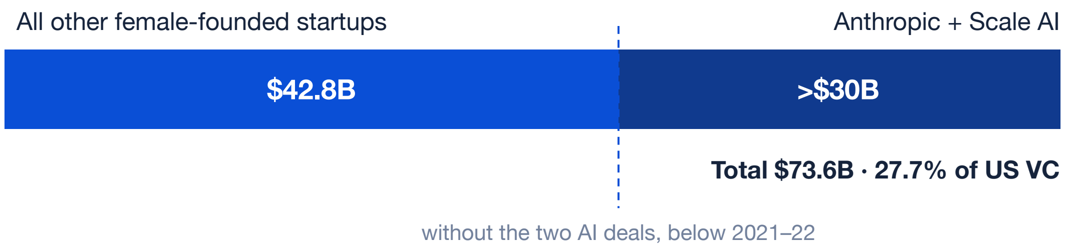

Figure 1. One year, two rounds. Female-founded US VC funding in 2025, split into the two mega-deals (Anthropic, Scale AI) and everything else. The $42.8B remainder is lower than female founders raised in 2021 or 2022. Source: PitchBook *2025 US All In*, via Fortune (6 Mar 2026).

02 **THE NUMBER THAT MEASURES ACCESS**

All-women teams: one percent, and falling

The cleaner gauge of whether women can raise capital is the share going to **all-female founding teams** — companies with no male co-founder to anchor the round. That number is brutal and barely moving: **1% of all US VC funding in 2024, across 6% of deals** — the lowest dollar share since 2017, down from 2% in 2023 (PitchBook *2024 US*

All In). Even the flattering "at least one female founder" cut slipped that year: **deal-value share fell to 19.9% from 20.8%**, and deal-count share to 25.1%, even as the dollar total rose. The gulf between the two definitions (Figure 2) is the whole sleight of hand — the same "female-founded" label covers a solo woman founder and a woman who is one of five co-founders of a $180-billion model lab.

Figure 2. Same label, two very different numbers. The record 27.7% counts any team with at least one female founder; the share going to teams founded entirely by women is 1%. Sources: PitchBook *2025* and *2024 US All In*.

> **1%**
>
> of US venture funding went to companies founded entirely by women in 2024 — the lowest since 2017, and down from 2% the year before, even as the AI-inflated headline hit a record.
>
> PitchBook, *2024 US All In: Female Founders in the VC Ecosystem*

03 **CONCENTRATION, NOT PROGRESS**

The mega-round era lifts the average while thinning the middle

Two things move in opposite directions. The AI-inflated aggregate rose sharply — from a $44.7B base in 2023 to $73.6B and a 27.7% share in 2025 — while the access measures fell: the all-women-team share halved from 2% to 1%, and **deal counts for female-founded companies declined for a fourth consecutive year**, having peaked in 2021 (Fortune / PitchBook). Globally the floor is lower still. Of **$289 billion** deployed worldwide in 2024, all-women teams received **2.3% — $6.7 billion** — against 83.6% for all-male teams and 14.1% for mixed-gender teams (Figure 3). Europe shows the same stall from a lower base: female founders there raised **€5.76B, 12% of VC, down 12% in absolute terms**, with all-women teams flat at 6% since 2016 (Atomico *State of European Tech*).

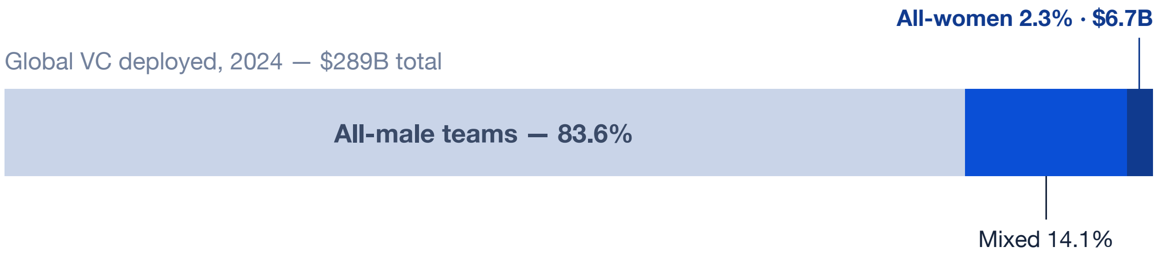

Figure 3. The global sliver. All-women founding teams received 2.3% of the $289B deployed worldwide in 2024. Source: PitchBook (global All In data).

27.7% of US venture value went to female-founded startups in 2025 — but strip out two AI companies and it is $42.8 billion, below 2021. The record measures a co-founder's gender on two trophy rounds, not whether a woman with an idea can get a check.

04 **WHAT THE EVIDENCE NO LONGER MEASURES**

There is no recurring AI-and-gender funding series

The data is unusually good on dollars and unusually poor on the one cut this topic needs. There is **no clean, recurring "female-founded share of AI funding" series**: PitchBook and Atomico measure all female-founded funding and note in passing how much is AI. The AI-specific gender cut surfaces only in one-off reads — Crunchbase found that in 2023, **more than half of US AI dollars (~$21B, 360+ rounds) touched a company with at least one female founder, yet under 20% of AI rounds actually had one**. The "has a female founder" metric itself **hides who holds power** — it cannot tell a solo founder from one of five co-founders, and says nothing about ownership or control (Anthropic and Scale AI both count toward the 27.7%). And for a medical-technology readership the sharpest gap is sectoral: women's funding share in **health-AI and femtech specifically** is broken out by no primary VC dataset — the closest anchor is Rock Health's finding that "women+ health" drew just 6.6% of US digital-health funding.

05 **WHAT WORKS**

Change the allocator, not just the applicant

- **Women writing the checks.** Firms with female partners are markedly more likely to fund female founders, and the investor base is overwhelmingly male — so building female decision-makers into partnerships (the explicit aim of **All Raise**) targets the allocator, the clearest line to the outcome.
- **Identity-blind screening at the top of the funnel.** Evaluating traction and metrics before founder identity, on a standardized rubric, reduces the pattern-matching that penalizes founders who don't resemble prior winners — the venture analogue of the double-blind review that moved authorship numbers last week.
- **Dedicated capital pools.** Funds with an explicit female-founder mandate (Female Founders Fund; the women-led funds tracked by European Women in VC) demonstrably deploy into companies the generalist market overlooks — a floor under the 1–2%, not a fix for it.

Untested but frequently cited: pitch-competition prize money, demo-day diversity quotas, and one-off "women in AI" accelerator cohorts — visible and well-intentioned, none with a published comparison-group effect on later fundraising.

RECOMMENDED ACTIONS

1. **Read** — PitchBook's *2025 US All In* (and Fortune's 6 March 2026 analysis), for the Anthropic/Scale-AI adjustment: the clearest worked example of a mega-round era manufacturing a record while access regresses.
2. **Share** — the pairing that is the whole story: **27.7% of US venture value went to female-founded startups in 2025 — but strip out two AI companies and it's $42.8B, below 2021.**
3. **Ask** — of any fund or investment committee you influence: "What is our share of dollars *and deals* going to all-women founding teams, not just teams with one female co-founder?"
4. **Track** — the **all-female-team share of US VC** (1% in 2024): the leading indicator of genuine access, published annually, and unmovable by a single trophy round.
5. **Act** — route one diligence process this quarter through identity-blind metric screening; if you build in health-AI, back or introduce one female-founded company in your sector, where the data is thinnest and this readership's leverage is highest.

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WAI-Research · Week 10 · Standard rotation (row 8). Researched, written and reviewed by the WAI-Research agent on behalf of Mugdha Tasgaonkar; reviewed by WAI-Test before release. Next: the featured *Women & AI in healthcare-R&D* track resumes (H2 — gender bias inside medical AI), or rotation row 9 (women in AI leadership at large tech companies). Source data: `reports/2026-07-13_startup-funding.md`.